

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 1.2

PITCH

BASIC DEFINITIONS: SOLFÈGE, TETRACHORDS



WHAT IS SOLFÈGE?

(ALSO KNOWN AS SOL-FA, SOLFEGGIO, SOLMIZATION)

Solfège is a system that uses the syllables DO, RE, MI, FA, SOL, LA, TI*, DO to name the sounds used in singing. The names given to the notes serve to remind the singer of the correct distances between the notes of a melody. It is ideally suited for expressing relationships between notes, called **intervals**.

*“TI,” the next-to-the last syllable, is called “SI” in some countries.

WHAT IS THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN “FIXED DO” AND “MOVEABLE DO” SOLFÈGE?

The “**fixed DO**” is a system (used widely in Romance-language countries and Russia) based on the assumption that DO is always the note “C.” It is best suited for learning instrumental and complex modern vocal/choral music.

The “**moveable DO**” system expresses the relationships between pitches no matter what the actual pitch of “DO” is. It has parallels in the Byzantine chant system of note syllables (*ni, pa, vou, ga, di, ke, zo, di*), and has been used by **church singers** throughout history, from medieval Roman Catholic monks, to Russian Old Believers, to the Puritan singing schools of New England. It is ideally suited for learning Orthodox vocal and choral church music.

This course uses the “moveable DO” system.

WHAT IS A “TETRACHORD”?

A **tetrachord** (from the Greek: *tetra*=four, and *chord*=string) is a sequence of four contiguous musical notes, usually spanning the interval of a perfect fourth. The concept of the tetrachord goes back to ancient Greek musical theory. Historically, tetrachords have been one of the fundamental building blocks of larger arrays of musical notes, called **scales** and/or **modes**.

| Do Re Mi Fa | Sol La Ti Do |



Listen to the audio on the next slide.

| Do Re Mi  | Sol La Ti Do |

THE GUIDONIAN HAND

Guido of Arezzo (991/992 – after 1033) was a Benedictine monk and an Italian music theorist of the Medieval era. He is regarded as the inventor of modern staff notation that replaced neumatic notation.

He developed a system for teaching musical notes by pointing at the various portions of the fingers of the hand.

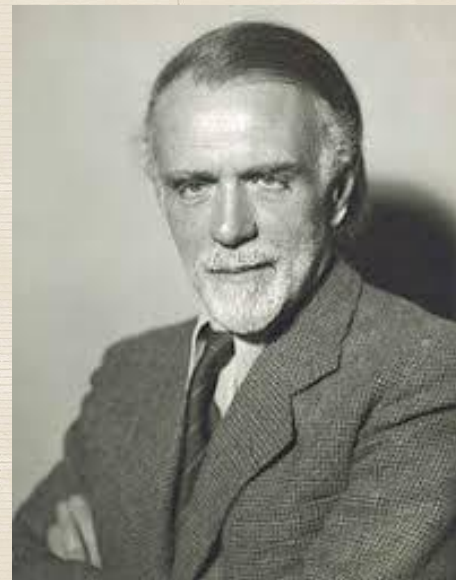
Using the first syllables of a Gregorian hymn to St. John the Baptist, he also gave us the syllables we use to name the pitches: UT(DO), RE, MI, FA, SOL, LA, TI



KODALY HAND SIGNS

Zoltán Kodály (1882-1967), who was introduced in the previous unit, adopted a system of hand signs that has been used with great effectiveness to teach the upward and downward movement of musical notes by relating them to visual cues.

You may find it helpful to use the hand signs as you practice the exercises in this course.





Do



Re



Mi



Fa



Sol



La



Ti



Do

KODALY HAND SIGNS

Any questions?

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You are now ready to
EXPLORE THE DO-FA TETRACHORD

Please proceed to
PITCH EXERCISES 1.1

